

The 6:15

SUNDAY · AUGUST 23, 2026

NO. 5

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS (WEEKEND, CONDENSED)

Mon 8/24–Wed 8/26 Mon: Bessent presser detailing Trump’s “Economic D-Day” Iran sanctions; Tue: Oregon primary, Intuit & Dick’s Sporting Goods earnings; Wed: Nvidia aft. close (cons. rev ~\$91.8B), Salesforce & CrowdStrike aft. close, July PCE + Q2 GDP 2nd est. + durable goods 8:30a (BEA), Lisa Cook’s deadline to respond to Trump’s removal letter.

Thu 8/27–Tue 9/16 Thu: Marvell aft. close, jobless claims, Jackson Hole opens (thru 8/29); Fri: Warsh’s first Jackson Hole keynote, 10:00a ET; Tue 9/16: next FOMC decision.

[NEW] Starcloud’s \$250M Series A extension (8/21, \$2.3B post-money) was the week’s notable VC print; no confirmed rocket launch or new frontier AI model this window beyond Z.AI’s GLM-5.2 Turbo (8/17, already logged last issue).

METRICS — WEEKEND, CONDENSED (NO FRESH SETTLE SINCE FRI 8/21)

Oil & rates Brent \$93.40–93.87 / WTI \$86.20–86.64 **(Fri 8/21 close, unreconciled across aggregators)** — both +~\$5 (~6%) vs. last Monday’s \$88.52 Brent settle. UST 2y/10y/30y (Fed H.15, 8/20): 4.19% / 4.74% / 5.26%. DXY 98.84 (Fri, +0.04%); VIX 15.13 (Fri, –5.5%).

Equities & other Gold \$4,607.35 spot (Fri, +2.03%, on fiscal jitters after Treasury upsized long-bond buybacks). S&P 7,674.37 (Fri, +0.43%, but –1.4% wk); Nasdaq –2.05% wk. Nikkei 66,016.36 (Fri, –0.30%); Hang Seng +1.06% intraday Fri. Retail gas \$4.102/gal natl. avg (AAA, 8/22), +\$0.04 wk/wk.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure Day 175 (straits.live, 8/22)

MoU status 60-day US-Iran MoU (signed 6/17) expired 8/17; Tehran declared it nullified, announced mandatory transit permits + new tolls; Washington rejects claim, keeps convoys/blockade

Transits	3 vessels Sun 8/16, 5 Sat 8/15, 12 Fri 8/14 (Kpler daily); weekly count 73 for 8/10–16 vs. 91 prior wk, 22 in/21 out non-Iranian-linked (Lloyd's List, prelim)
Backlog	~520 vessels stuck in Arabian Gulf, up to 8-wk clear time (single-sourced this run)
Seizure	Tanker Amara (Liberia-flag, UAE-linked mgmt) seized near Qeshm 8/17 — first since 6/22; held stationary 2nd consecutive day as of 8/21 (Windward)
Strike	Bulk carrier Minoan Dignity hit by projectile in engine room, overnight 8/17–18, exiting southern corridor — chief engineer killed; 2nd strike this month on a Modion Maritime vessel (after Minoan Pioneer, 8/4)
War-risk premium	3–10% of hull value broadly; VLCC-specific \$10–14M/passage (Lloyd's List/Marsh, late July — stale, no fresher figure located)
Dark tankers	not confirmed as of press time — no discrete current figure located this run

Three measurement frames, not netted: Kpler publishes near-real-time AIS-visible daily transit counts; Lloyd's List Intelligence aggregates weekly commercial transits >10,000 dwt with Iran-link attribution, preliminary/revised; straits.live tracks a running day-count since the 2/28 closure declaration plus broker-sourced war-risk quotes at irregular refresh.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	3B Ryan McMahon 10-day IL (retro 8/20, Grade 2 thumb sprain), Max Schuemann recalled from AAA; LHP Max Fried 15-day IL (retro 8/14, elbow, possible Sept return); DH Stanton (calf) season availability in doubt; LF Bellinger (hamstring) expected back today
Knicks / Northwestern	Hart extension talks reportedly trending 3-yr/\$60–62M (vs. 4-yr/\$132M max) (reported terms, not team-confirmed) — still unsigned. Northwestern: no news this weekend.

LEAD

HORMUZ • SANCTIONS

Iran's ceasefire lapses into a seizure and a fatal strike; Bessent's "Economic D-Day" lands Monday.

The 60-day US-Iran memorandum of understanding, signed June 17 to buy time for a “final deal,” expired Wednesday with no agreement — and the five days since have shown what that lapse actually means on the water. Tehran declared the MoU nullified by US violations and announced mandatory transit permits and new “maritime environmental tolls” for the strait; Washington rejected the claim and kept its convoy escorts and blockade enforcement in place. Within hours, Iran made its first tanker seizure since June 22 — boarding the Liberia-flagged, UAE-linked tanker Amara near Qeshm Island — and, overnight Aug. 17-18, an unidentified projectile struck the bulk carrier Minoan Dignity’s engine room as it exited the strait’s southern corridor, killing the chief engineer. It was the second strike this month on a vessel managed by the same Greek operator, Modion Maritime, after the Minoan Pioneer on Aug. 4. *(Read: the seizure and the strike, arriving within a day of each other and of the MoU’s expiry, look less like coincidence than Iran demonstrating what enforcement of its new transit rules will cost anyone who doesn’t pay.)*

Transit data confirms the chilling effect. Kpler counted just three vessels crossing Sunday Aug. 16, five the day before, 12 the day before that — traffic that Lloyd’s List Intelligence’s slower weekly count put at 73 transits for Aug. 10-16, down from 91 the prior week. An estimated 520 vessels are now backed up in the Arabian Gulf, with an up-to-eight-week clearing time even in an optimistic reopening scenario **(single-sourced this run)**. The UAE, which had stayed rhetorically firm through five months of attacks without directly retaliating, went further this week: it cut all economic and financial ties with Iran, accusing Tehran of firing ballistic missiles at Emirati territory — a charge Iran denies. The UAE is Iran’s largest

source of imports and third-largest export market, worth more than \$7 billion; severing it removes one of the last commercial arteries Tehran had left running.

Into that backdrop, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent holds a press conference Monday to detail what Trump has branded “Economic D-Day” — what Bessent calls a “one-two punch” pairing the existing naval blockade with what he’s promising will be the “toughest sanctions in history,” explicitly aimed at collapsing the regime rather than merely constraining it. Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi got out ahead of it, dismissing the campaign on social media as “a diversion from America’s own crisis: unprecedented debt and surging interest costs” and running through a list of past US pressure campaigns he says all failed — “crippling sanctions,” “maximum pressure,” “unconditional surrender.” *(Read: bravado aside, Araghchi’s framing — that Washington is the one under fiscal strain — reads as a play to the domestic audience that matters most to Tehran right now, a public increasingly squeezed by an economy it “cannot sell oil” out of, per President Pezeshkian’s comment two weeks ago.)*

Oil is the cleanest read on how markets are pricing the sequence. Brent, which settled at \$88.52 a week ago Friday, closed Friday in a \$93.40-93.87 range across aggregators — a roughly \$5, or 6%, jump that tracks the MoU’s collapse and Bessent’s escalation more than any single headline. **(No clean single ICE settle located this run; range reflects genuine cross-source divergence.)** WTI moved similarly, into an \$86.20-86.64 range. National retail gasoline followed, to \$4.102 a gallon Saturday — up four cents on the week and roughly a dollar above year-ago levels. The mechanical read for Monday: Bessent’s press conference is now a two-way risk event for

crude, capable of moving the complex either on the specifics of what gets sanctioned or on Iran's next retaliatory move if the response is severe enough to threaten the regime's remaining revenue base.

POLITICS

Lisa Cook's deadline to respond to Trump's renewed removal effort is now three days out (Wed. 8/26). Her attorneys, Abbe Lowell and Norm Eisen, reiterated this week that the mortgage-fraud allegations are "as baseless now as they were a year ago" — setting up a decision point that lands the same day as Nvidia earnings and the PCE/GDP data cluster. (*Developing.*) The Senate-House funding gap — the Senate's CR runs to Dec. 11, the House's own version only to Dec. 4 — remains unresolved with the House still in recess; funding technically lapses Sept. 30 if neither chamber acts, though neither side has signaled new urgency this week.

ECONOMICS

Wednesday's FOMC July minutes broke more hawkish than the post-payrolls narrative suggested: the committee's 9-3 vote to hold at 3.50%-3.75% understated the split — Cleveland's Hammack, Minneapolis's Kashkari and Dallas's Logan dissented for a hike — and the minutes noted hawkish sentiment "extended well beyond the three dissenters," with some officials saying current financial conditions may not be tight enough to bring inflation back to target. Separately, Chair Warsh floated cutting FOMC meetings from eight a year to six, arguing it would let more data accumulate between decisions. Derivatives-market odds for a September cut remain negligible on Kalshi/Polymarket pricing; a September hike, once dismissed, is no longer trivial to price out given the minutes. (*Read.*)

BUSINESS

Anthropic is preparing to publicly file its IPO prospectus as soon as end of August, aiming for an October debut and reportedly targeting a \$2 trillion valuation — against its \$965 billion May Series H — on a run rate that reached \$65 billion at the end of July. **(Valuation target reported, not company-confirmed.)** Nvidia is backstopping up to \$105 billion in financing for a 10-gigawatt SB Energy/OpenAI data-center campus in Pike County, Ohio, guaranteeing the site's compute exclusively to Nvidia hardware and investing \$1.5 billion directly in SB Energy; first capacity (800MW) isn't due online until 2028. Equities closed a rough week on a Friday bounce — S&P 500 +0.43% to 7,674.37, but -1.4% on the week (Nasdaq -2.05%) amid Treasury-market volatility.

TECHNOLOGY

Microsoft's reported push for 300,000+ Maia AI chips at TSMC — flagged single-sourced in the prior issue — now has multiple outlets citing a Maia 300 unveiling as soon as September, with an eventual target near 1 million units; neither Microsoft nor TSMC has confirmed unit figures on the record. *(Developing.)* No new frontier-model release logged since Z.AI's GLM-5.2 Turbo (8/17, already noted); Google's flagship Gemini 3.5 Pro remains delayed with no new date surfaced this run.

GEOPOLITICS

Russia and Ukraine traded heavy strikes again Saturday — Russian attacks killed at least 7 and wounded 31 across Ukraine, including a strike near the Moldova border crossing; Ukrainian strikes killed at least 10 in Russia and occupied territory, and for the first time hit Ozon, Russia's second-largest online retailer, sparking a fire at its Samara Oblast warehouse and evacuating 500+ employees. Putin warned of “far more destructive” retaliatory strikes on Ukrainian economic infrastructure. *(Read: a deliberate hit on civilian e-commerce infrastructure, rather than a military-industrial target, marks an escalation in what counts as fair game for Kyiv.)* Xi's Sept. 24 Washington summit remains on the calendar with export controls the unresolved friction point; no new developments surfaced this run.

IRAN & HORMUZ

The threat level in the strait is now rated SEVERE by maritime security trackers, the tightest classification of this five-month crisis, with the Amara's continued detention near Qeshm — held stationary for a second consecutive day as of Thursday — underscoring that Iran's new permit-and-toll regime is being enforced, not merely announced. Tehran's public position is that the MoU's expiry restores its full authority over the strait; Washington has not indicated any change to convoy escorts or the blockade in response to the seizure. *(Developing.)* Cumulative strike counts for the crisis were not updated with a reconcilable figure this run — the prior issue's range (56-65, sources diverging) should be read as a floor, not a current total. **(Not confirmed as of press time.)**

SPORTS

Yankees	Won 3-1 Fri 8/21 over Toronto (5th straight win; rookie Spencer Jones's 2-run HR upheld on replay), then dropped Sat 8/22, 4-3. 73-55, 2nd AL East.
Knicks	Off-season, no game. Hart extension talks ongoing (see Transactions) — still unsigned.
Northwestern	Off-season, no game or roster news this weekend; opener remains Sat 9/5, 7:00p CT vs. South Dakota State.

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged since 8/17: Khamenei/IRGC command reshuffle, Oman shipping-lane routing map, TSMC July revenue, Northwestern's QB competition. Weekend issue: Metrics/Calendar condensed to two lines each, Economics/Business kept only because the FOMC minutes and Anthropic/Nvidia items broke this week, Sports condensed to two lines/team per weekend format.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.